



IMMIGRATION officers seize a flag-waving protester Thursday outside a federal building in Minneapolis.

NEW STRAIN HAS FLU CASES SURGING

California officials warn of an increase in hospitalizations amid elevated activity.

By Karen Garcia

California officials are issuing warnings about a new flu strain that is increasing flu-related cases and hospitalizations statewide, with public health experts across the nation echoing the alerts.

A newly emerged influenza A strain, H3N2 sub-clade K, is already wreaking havoc globally and is affecting hospitals and clinics in California, the state's Department of Public Health announced Tuesday. The agency described the seasonal flu activity as "elevated" in the state; data show that flu test positivity rates, which measure the percentage of patients who come in with flu symptoms and actually test positive for influenza, have been rising in recent weeks. However, they are still relatively low compared with last year's flu season.

"Flu started to rise, in earnest, by mid-December and rates are still up," said Dr. Elizabeth Hudson, regional physician chief of infectious diseases for Kaiser Permanente. "We are hoping to see some plateauing in the next few weeks, but there's some delay in data due to recent holidays, so it will become clearer in the next week or so."

Hudson said most flu-related cases are being treated without the need for hospital admittance, "but those who are older or at higher risk for complications from the flu are the ones we're mostly seeing admitted."

According to data from the public health agency, [See Flu, A8]

A call for safety measures as Mt. Baldy trails reopen

By Alex Wigglesworth

Trails on Mt. Baldy reopened after the deaths of three hikers who fell from an ice-slicked ridge last month in what investigators believed to be two unrelated incidents.

That doesn't mean conditions are safe, warned the agency responsible for handling rescues there: Snow, ice, limited visibility and the potential for sudden storms persist.

Twenty-three people have died on the mountain

outside Los Angeles over the last decade, and crews have responded to 345 search-and-rescue calls on its slopes, the San Bernardino County Sheriff's Department said in a news release that criticized the U.S. Forest Service, which manages the area, for not doing more to prevent injuries and deaths.

"The frequency of rescues our department is involved in annually, and the lack of concern for what's happening on Mt. Baldy by those who are responsible for maintaining visitors' safety needs to be addressed," San Bernardino County Sheriff Shannon Dicus said in a statement. "For the last several years, our department has been trying to have the U.S. Forest Service more involved in keeping people safe while they recreate on Mt Baldy."

Dicus said that he continued to meet with representatives from the agency and Congress to express his concerns. In the past, he's called for the Forest Service to temporarily close the mountain during unsafe weather

[See Mt. Baldy, A12]



CREWS have responded to 345 search-and-rescue calls on Mt. Baldy in a decade.

Judge skeptical on ICE masks

State's ban could cause chaos, federal lawyer argues

By Sonja Sharp

A top Trump administration lawyer has pressed a federal judge to block a newly enacted California law that bans most law enforcement officers in the state from wearing masks, including U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents.

Tiberius Davis, representing the U.S. Department of Justice, argued at a hearing Wednesday in Los Angeles that the first-of-its-kind ban on police face coverings could unleash chaos

across the country, and potentially land many ICE agents on the wrong side of the law if it were allowed to take effect.

"Why couldn't California say every immigration officer needs to wear pink, so it's super obvious who they are?" Davis told U.S. District Judge Christina A. Snyder. "The idea that all 50 states can regulate the conduct and uniforms of officers ... flips the Constitution on its head."

The judge appeared skeptical.

"Why can't they perform their duties without a mask?"

They did that until 2025, did they not?" Snyder said. "How in the world do those who don't mask manage to operate?"

The administration first sued to block the new rules in November, after Gov. Gavin Newsom signed the No Secret Police Act and its companion provision, the No Vigilantes Act, into law. The laws bar law enforcement officers from wearing masks and compel them to display identification "while conducting law enforcement operations in the Golden State." Both offenses would [See Masks, A8]

Trump threatens Insurrection Act against protesters

His warning comes after Minneapolis man is shot in face-off with federal agents.

By Jenny Jarvie and Sonja Sharp

President Trump threatened Thursday to invoke the Insurrection Act as part of his crackdown on immigration, blaming Democratic politicians in Minnesota who have opposed Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents' presence in the city and decried their violence against protesters.

"If the corrupt politicians of Minnesota don't obey the law and stop the professional agitators and insurrectionists from attacking the Patriots of I.C.E., who are only trying to do their job, I will institute the INSURRECTION ACT," Trump wrote in a post on his social media website.

The president made his threat a day after a federal immigration officer in Minneapolis shot an undocumented immigrant from Venezuela in the leg. The agency said the man, whom they identified as Julio Cesar Sosa-Celis, was one of three men who attacked federal officers with a shovel and a broom as an altercation broke out after federal

agents tried to complete a targeted traffic stop.

"What we saw last night in Minneapolis was an attempted murder of federal law enforcement," Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem said in a statement. "Mayor Frey and Governor Walz have to get their city under control. They are encouraging impeding and assault against our law enforcement which is a federal crime, a felony. This is putting the people of Minnesota in harm's way."

If Trump invoked the Insurrection Act — a 200-year-old constellation of statutes that grant the president emergency powers to thrust active-duty soldiers into civilian police duty — he could bring in federal troops to quell protests. But scholars argue his legal standing is "wildly tenuous."

"The president has threatened to invoke the Insurrection Act so many times it can be difficult to distinguish between a real threat and a false alarm," said Elizabeth Goitein, senior director of the Liberty and National Security Program at New York University's Brennan Center for Justice.

Other experts cautioned this time could be more serious.

"I think he'll do it," Kevin Carroll, former senior counsel [See Trump, A6]

Charges of fixing college basketball

Gamblers allegedly bribed former players of 17 Division I teams in point-shaving plot.

By Steve Henson

Twenty-six people were charged in connection with an alleged bribery and point-shaving scheme involving men's basketball games at the NCAA Division I and Chinese professional levels, U.S. Atty. David Metcalf announced Thursday in Pennsylvania.

The bribery charges carry a maximum sentence of five years and the fraud charges up to 20 years.

The indictment is the latest in a string of illegal gambling and game-fixing episodes in the seven years since the Supreme Court struck down the Professional and Amateur Sports Protection Act of 1992, the federal statute that restricted legal betting to primarily Nevada.

Dozens of professional and college athletes and coaches have been suspended, fired or prosecuted

for alleged gambling violations. This latest indictment only adds to the ledger.

"This was a massive scheme that enveloped the world of college basketball," Metcalf said. "This was a significant and rampant corruption of college athletics."

The most prominent player named in the indictment was Antonio Blakeney, the leading scorer at Louisiana State in 2016-17 and a veteran of two seasons with the Chicago Bulls. The shooting guard has played for professional teams in China, Israel and Bahrain since last playing in the NBA in 2019. The indictment describes Blakeney as being "charged elsewhere."

The U.S. Attorney's Office for the Eastern District of Pennsylvania filed the sweeping indictment, which involves 15 players from 17 college teams over the last four years. The scheme allegedly involved two gamblers — Shane Hennen and Marves Fairley — who were indicted in October for alleged roles in an NBA sports gambling scheme that allegedly included Miami Heat player Terry Rozier. [See Sports bribery, A8]

Iran protests appear stifled in crackdown

By Jon Gambrell

DUBAI — The nationwide protests challenging Iran's theocracy appeared increasingly smothered Thursday, a week after authorities shut the country off from the world and escalated a bloody crackdown that activists say has killed at least 2,637 people.

The prospect of U.S. retaliation for the protesters' deaths still hung over the region, though President

Trump signaled a possible de-escalation, saying the killing appeared to be ending. The White House stressed that "all options remain on the table."

Meanwhile, the U.S. announced new sanctions on Iranian officials accused of suppressing the protests, which began late last month over the country's faltering economy and the collapse of its currency. The Group of 7 industrialized democracies and the European Union said they too were looking at

new sanctions to ratchet up the pressure on Iran's theocratic government.

The United Nations Security Council began an emergency meeting on Iran on Thursday afternoon at the request of the U.S.

In Iran's capital, Tehran, witnesses said recent mornings showed no new signs of bonfires lighted the night before or debris in the streets. The sound of gunfire, which had been intense for several nights, also has faded.

Iranian state media announced wave after wave of arrests by authorities, targeting those it calls "terrorists" while also apparently looking for Starlink satellite internet dishes, which offer the only way to get videos and images out to the internet.

"Since Jan. 8 we saw a full-fledged war, and anybody who was in the gathering since then is a criminal," Justice Minister Amin Hossein Rahimi said, according [See Iran, A3]

L.A. film, TV shoot days plunge 16%

The total for 2025 was a big drop from 2024, and was the lowest since the pandemic began. **BUSINESS, A10**

Superbloom chances wilting

Despite a lot of rain, the unseasonably hot, dry SoCal weather isn't helping wildflower prospects. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Children's exhibit makes a splash

Skirball Cultural Center's Noah's Ark display reopens with enhanced spaces to explore and play. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Sunny and very warm. L.A. Basin: 80/55. **B6**

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TOM WILLIAMS CQ-Roll Call Inc. **MARÍA CORINA** Machado at the Capitol.

Machado offers Trump her medal

President is unconvinced that the Nobel Peace Prize laureate has the support to lead Venezuela. **NATION, A5**

Markets A12
Opinion Voices A13